

In the middle of it, with everyone watching

8 findings · 13-step checklist · 1 myth · 7 sources · cheatgrid.com

You're in a store aisle with your toddler mid-meltdown, convinced everyone walking past has judged you, and part of what you want right now is for it to stop so people stop looking, not only because it's what she needs.

THE GOAL

You're trying to steady your own reaction long enough for her anger to burn out on its own, not to make the tantrum **end on command**.

CHECKLIST

The moment you notice someone looking over while she's still mid-meltdown.

- ☐ Look back down at her instead of at whoever you noticed watching.
- ☐ Slide the cart out of the main path and move anything within her reach that she could grab or knock over.
- ☐ Crouch down to her level, angled so your back faces the aisle instead of her.
- ☐ Unclench your jaw and hands, and take **one slow breath** before you do anything else.
- ☐ If she's hitting, kicking, or near something breakable, say one short line telling her what to do instead, like 'feet down.'
- ☐ If nothing around her is unsafe, wait where you are and let her continue without a comment or a question.
- ☐ If a stranger comments or hovers, give one short line that closes it off, like 'we're okay, thanks,' then turn back to her.
- ☐ Watch for her crying to soften and her breathing to slow: that's the shift out of **the angriest part**.
- ☐ When you see that shift, hold out a hand or open your arms **without pulling her toward you**.
- ☐ Once she reaches for you, hold her as long as she wants without talking about what happened yet.
- ☐ When she's calm enough to stand on her own, decide in that moment whether to keep going or head to checkout.
- ☐ If you're staying, pick the cart back up and carry on from where you stopped.
- ☐ If you're leaving, hand any open or opened items to a staff member or the checkout counter rather than a shelf.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1** That spike of dread when you clock someone watching isn't only about her tantrum. It's your own body reacting to being on display while stuck in something **you can't fix on command**.
- 2** Explaining or arguing while she's still screaming and kicking won't get through, and it can **stretch the tantrum out** rather than end it.
- 3** Force doesn't speed this up. Grabbing, restraining, or swatting to make her comply works no better than leaving her untouched.

What's true, not what it feels like

KNOW

That spike of dread when you clock someone watching isn't only about her tantrum. It's your own body reacting to being on display while stuck in something **you can't fix on command**.

People asked to do a hard task while others watch show bigger, longer-lasting stress spikes than people doing the identical task unobserved. [Source 4](#)

KNOW

You're overcounting how many people noticed. Tested directly, people's guesses about who would notice and remember an awkward moment ran at **roughly double the real count**.

In the study, people wearing an embarrassing T-shirt guessed nearly twice as many onlookers would recognize it as the number who could. [Source 5](#)

KNOW

You're overestimating how harshly anyone here would judge you for this, **if they judged you at all**.

In several tests, people who imagined an embarrassing slip braced for harsher judgment than the people who watched it gave. [Source 6](#)

DO

Naming a couple of other explanations a stranger might land on, instead of the one you're dreading, brings your guess about their judgment closer to what they'd think.

In one test, people who first listed other possible reasons for how they'd be seen predicted the real reaction more accurately. [Source 6](#)

KNOW

This won't last as long as it feels. In one study that timed hundreds of real tantrums, the single most common length was under a minute, and three in four ended within 5 minutes.

Those tantrum lengths were timed from parents' detailed, minute-by-minute accounts of what happened, not guessed at afterward. [Source 7](#)

What's going on with her, not with you

DON'T

Explaining or arguing while she's still screaming and kicking won't get through, and it can **stretch the tantrum out** rather than end it.

Responding to her mid-scream may add **more for her to process** than she can handle at the peak of her anger. [Source 1](#)

SAY

Instead of a why-explanation, give her one short, plain instruction she can act on, like 'feet down,' and save the real conversation for once she's fully calm.

A short instruction is something she can act on mid-scream, unlike a reason, which works better once she's calm. [Source 2](#)

DON'T

Force doesn't speed this up. Grabbing, restraining, or swatting to make her comply works no better than leaving her untouched.

Watched covertly in real public settings, children who were grabbed or hit weren't more likely to comply than children who weren't touched at all. [Source 3](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

A tantrum runs through clean, separate phases: first anger and yelling, then physical acting out, then finally sadness once the anger has burned off.

ACTUALLY

That's not how it works. The same research this claim leans on found the opposite: **anger peaks right at the start** while crying and reaching for comfort build up across the whole tantrum, not only after the anger ends. [Source 1](#)

Sources

1. <https://www.npr.org/sections/health-shots/2011/12/05/143062378/whats-behind-a-temper-tantrum-scientists-deconstruct-the-screams>
2. <https://www.psychologytoday.com/nz/blog/parenting-from-a-neuroscience-perspective/202002/tantrums-meltdowns-and-everything-in-between>
3. <https://www.nbcnews.com/id/wbna48490527>
4. https://www.psychiatry.wisc.edu/courses/Nitschke/seminar/dickerson_kemeny_metaanalysis%202004%20psych%20bull.pdf
5. https://www.psychologyib.com/uploads/1/1/7/5/11758934/the_spotlight_effect_-_ib_psychology.pdf
6. https://uploads-ssl.webflow.com/5c484e0f4aa6f839dc553c45/5c818f250431906545090748_SavitskyEpleyGilovich2001.pdf
7. <https://chm-web.files.svdcn.com/production/files-publications/PotegalTemper2DevelopmentalAndBehavioralPediatrics.pdf?dm=1763410075>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Little children and big feelings at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](#)